



12 ARTICLES ON PRODUCTIVITY

Tips on Getting More Done Every Day

ABSTRACT

Our goal with these productivity articles is to share our experience and wisdom on how, regardless of what you do, you can get more done, get it done better, and have more time for the rest of your life.

12 Articles on Productivity



Introduction

We've written a lot about productivity over the years. It's been a focus in our writing because one of our goals at Integrify is to make our customers more productive through automation and standardization.

But what does it mean to be productive?

Some might say that being productive means meeting your peak potential every day. Others might say it's completing more tasks in a set time period. Both definitions are valid because productivity varies from role to role and goal to goal. For instance, a finance director and an HR recruiter have much different expectations from day to day.

Our goal with these productivity articles is to share our experience and wisdom on how, regardless of what you do, you can get more done, get it done better, and have more time for the rest of your life.

If you find any of these articles helpful, please share them with your colleagues. If you want to learn more about our workflow automation software (which gives you more time to be productive), please visit us at www.integrify.com.

Yours in productivity,

The Integrify Team

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Find Your Flow by Reducing Distractions and Task Apathy

By Joanne Wortman



What is the "Flow"?

High-functioning organizations often harness insights from human psychology to boost efficiency and productivity in the workplace. Personal productivity coaches help their clients attain peak "flow" as they tackle difficult tasks or work toward personal goals. If you have ever felt like you were "in the zone" while practicing a hobby or sport, you have experienced the state of flow. Complete attention, lack of awareness of time passing, ability to ignore personal needs and a true zeal for the work at hand are some of the key characteristics of this state. [Psychologists](#) describe flow as:

"Being completely involved in an activity for its own sake. The ego falls away. Time flies. Every action, movement, and thought follows inevitably from the previous one, like playing jazz. Your whole being is involved, and you're using your skills to the utmost."

Barriers to Flow in the Workplace

Traditional workplaces often place high barriers to flow - even the most committed employees find it difficult to overcome the obstacles of distraction and information chaos.

The True Cost of Distractions

Wouldn't it be great if employees could spend more of their time in this flow state while tackling their responsibilities? One [recent study](#) estimates that **3 hours and 12 minutes per person, per day**, are spent on distracting interruptions that are of minimal value to the goals of the organization. Interruptions chew up 40% of an 8-hour workday.

Distracting interruptions have many sources:

- A personal schedule that is crammed with poorly-run meetings leaves little time for deep focus on the personal task list
- Unclear direction that requires multiple emails or ad hoc desk-side "Got a minute?" discussions to resolve
- Social chatter - both in-person and via email, texting and instant messaging
- Self-distraction from task apathy toward difficult or mundane tasks

A [recent study](#) shows that these and other workplace distractions are costing the U.S. economy \$588 million per year. Distractions erode employee morale, increase employee turnover, cause more errors, and reduce customer satisfaction. A chaotic workplace with constant distractions drives up personal stress levels, saps employees' mental and physical wellbeing, and decreases attention span - making it impossible for anyone to reach the desired state of flow.



The Information Scramble

Poorly organized information sends employees on a treasure hunt when working through a task, causing productivity-eroding confusion:

- Sending requests for information to too many email recipients because it's not clear who is the authoritative source for the needed information
- Copying too many people on status updates
- Inviting non-essential employees to meetings
- Clogging inboxes with too many reminders
- Manual workflows that involve offline calculation or physically hunting through paper files
- Publishing ad hoc changes to procedures in an email blast that may be forgotten when workers are performing the task a few weeks later

To foster flow, you need to put correct, up-to-date information in the right person's hands at the right point in the workflow. Workflow changes should be enforced within the workflow itself. Don't rely on the faulty memory of highly stressed employees who are working on deadlines.

Workflow Automation is Key to Fostering Higher Levels of Employee Flow

Clearly, management can foster a higher degree of flow by minimizing distractions in several ways:

- Tighten up your meeting culture:
 - Run meeting from a tight agenda
 - Enforce a no-cell-phone policy during meetings
 - Minimize meeting attendee list
 - Control meeting discussion that veers off-topic
- Institute meeting blackout periods to give employees larger blocks of time to complete their tasks
- Encourage a clean desk policy
- Monitor and minimize employee smartphone use during working hours. Even when silent smartphones vibrate, they are a distraction that interrupts employee flow.



These policies will help you make incremental progress toward promoting greater flow, but the biggest contribution to enhancing employee productivity comes from automating those workflows that are fraught with inherent interruptions: lookups, handoffs, and approval requests.

Workflow Automation refers to the design, execution, and automation of processes based on workflow rules where human tasks, data or files are routed between people or systems based on pre-defined business rules.

Workflow automation allows you to achieve straight-through processing of requests and claims and creates organized workflows for employees that process transactions. Instead of having a pile of transactions or requests on hold while waiting for the answers and approvals required to complete the task, each employee can process more items in one sequence of steps—or the system retains it in the queue marked with an in-progress status.

Automated workflow also gives managers insight into the efficiency of individual employees so that additional coaching, training, and assistance can be applied where needed.

Automation promotes greater flow within the organization in many ways:

- **Fewer interruptions** because many manual tasks are performed by the software in the background. Information that was keyed in manually can be pulled automatically from other software systems. Bear in mind that even the smallest interruptions in a workflow can be extremely harmful. A recent study from the [Journal of Experimental Psychology](#) revealed that an interruption as short as 2.8 seconds more than doubled the error rate when participants were asked to recall where they had left off in a sequence of tasks.
- **Fewer meetings** required to make decisions about "special exceptions" because automated (and easily reconfigurable) business rules are in place. Automated business rules substantially reduce [decision fatigue](#) and free up management time for more important responsibilities.

- **Less information chaos** because the workflow automation software routes the correct information to the right individual at the right point in the workflow
- **Better visibility** into task status without the need for email updates, chats or meetings
- **Task apathy disappears** because workers are no longer required to trudge through the unchallenging tasks of sending someone a copy of something via email, downloading a spreadsheet to update, looking up who to contact about a question or poking through paper files.
- **There is less follow-up lag** because certain transactions are no longer parked in a pile on someone's desk waiting for decisions or approvals.
- **Higher employee engagement** as their stress levels drop because there is clarity and independence about handling the tasks in the workflow
- **Greater customer satisfaction** when interactions are handled more professionally with greater speed
- **Less need for employee overtime** because transaction processing time is improved

The benefits of workflow automation are clear. The automation effort does not need to be a huge project that causes a major distraction to current operations. We can help you zero in on the most distracted areas within your business and configure appropriate automation that will foster better employee flow.

How to Be More Productive This Year

By Mike Raia



Staying on top of your calendar and to-do list can seem like an impossible goal sometimes. These strategies may help you make the best use of your time, lower stress and make you more productive.

Between personal obligations and professional responsibilities, it can seem as if there are never enough hours in the day. We can accumulate wealth and things, but try as we might, we'll never have more than the same 24 hours each day that everyone else has. The trick is to find ways to use time more efficiently.

Improving your personal productivity goes hand-in-hand with professional productivity, so when you implement strategies designed to boost one area of your life, odds are good you'll see gains in others too.

Plan for the Coming Day

You probably already know the importance of planning your day to maximize productivity and efficiency. However, planning your day – before you go to bed the night before – can help give you the structure and momentum you need to hit the ground running.

Writing a to-do list, prioritizing tasks and planning time on your calendar can [keep you from being reactive](#) the next day. What's more, it can help you get a better night's sleep because you won't be worrying about what you need to get done the next day.

Use Time Blocking Strategies

Organizing your day into [blocks of time](#), and planning to accomplish a certain task (or multiple tasks) in a given block of time may help you be more productive too, by helping keep you focused on the task at hand.

When all of your must-complete tasks are on a list rather than blocked off on your calendar, they can weigh on you, increasing your stress levels. By allotting a certain amount of time to each item and scheduling them, you'll likely find you are more disciplined and making better use of every minute. Remember to be realistic and give yourself some flexibility.

Get Enough Sleep

When you have a to-do list that seems never-ending, the idea of spending more of your time sleeping can seem counterintuitive. However, getting more sleep doesn't mean you're wasting time. It can [make you more productive](#) by helping you make fewer mistakes, recover faster from distractions, reduce the risk of burnout and actually improve your memory.

According to the [CDC](#), adults should be getting at least seven hours of sleep each night. If you're not getting enough rest, try to limit screen time before bed and consider using a fitness tracker or other sleep-tracking device to watch your sleep habits and patterns over time.

Create and Follow a Morning Routine

Everyone has occasional mornings when nothing seems to go right and getting out of the door on time seems like an impossible goal. However, if that's the norm rather than the exception, you could probably benefit from creating and sticking to a [morning workflow](#).

Waking up early (without hitting the snooze button) can give you much-needed time for yourself before the demands of the day begin. [Other morning habits](#) of successful entrepreneurs include avoiding sugar at the start of the day, drinking plenty of water, exercising to wake up your muscles and get your blood flowing, planning time for a healthy breakfast, and meditating or practicing mindfulness and gratitude.

Learn How to Say “No”

Saying “no” can be incredibly difficult for many people, however, productive people [know their limits](#) and have learned how to turn down things that aren’t aligned with their personal or professional priorities.

When evaluating demands on your time, consider what the full-time commitment would be, whether you’d be giving up other opportunities by saying “yes” (opportunity cost) and what the emotional and physical costs would mean for your wellbeing.

Work Where You Can be Most Productive

Spending 40-50 hours at your desk in the office may be the traditional way of working, but that doesn’t mean it’s the way you are most productive. [Embracing workplace flexibility](#) arrangements can make you happier, reduce stress and make you more productive because you have more control over how and when your work gets done.

Of course, your company needs to recognize the value of remote or flexible work arrangements. If you don’t have the opportunity to work from outside the office yet, you can still improve workplace productivity by [decluttering your workspace](#). Resist the urge to make (or add to) piles on your desk or floor of your office. Similarly, take control of digital clutter by organizing your email inbox and electronic files in a way that will help keep you focused while still giving you ready access to information when you need it.

Don’t Schedule Meetings Just to Have Meetings

At some point, most working professionals have had to [sit through meetings](#) where very little was actually accomplished. [Meeting for the sake of having a meeting](#) is not only a drain on productivity; it can also take a toll on morale and culture for the company.

When you need to call a meeting, start and end it on time. It's also important to take a good look at the invitee list. Meetings with fewer participants tend to be [more productive](#) than those with large numbers in attendance. Finally, have an agenda, state the desired outcomes at the beginning of the meeting, and let participants know you expect them to be prepared. By focusing on intentionally making the most of meetings, you can improve efficiency and productivity for everyone involved.

Take Breaks

Working nonstop won't help your productivity; it will hinder it. [Taking breaks](#) throughout your workday can make you more focused and resilient, but only if you actually use the time away from your desk to relax and leave your work at work.

Whether you take time to read, exercise, do yoga or start a new hobby, find ways to energize and fight stress during your workday. Using PTO or vacation days to take [time away from the office](#) – and not checking in every day while you're gone – is also an important key to improving your attitude, renewing your energy levels, refreshing your brain and increasing productivity when you return to work.

Automate Departmental Processes

Last but not least, centralizing tasks and leveraging technology to automate processes can provide significant gains in workplace productivity. In a [recent study](#), think tank McKinsey Global Institute estimated that automation could raise productivity growth globally by 0.8 to 1.4 percent annually.

Using automated workflows can help keep you – and others in your department – accountable by assigning tasks and concrete deadlines for those tasks. Relying on technology rather than on peoples' individual calendars or memories can also help ensure those deadlines are met by allowing you to set automated reminders when a task's due date is approaching (or to schedule progress check-ins periodically for larger projects.)

Automation can also assure next-level reviewers or those with subsequent tasks and responsibilities are notified right away when it's their turn to act, helping avoid bottlenecks and keeping the task or project moving.

Finally, centralizing and automating processes can also help project- and team leaders, allowing them to customize and schedule delivery of automated reports. Department managers using automated workflows can see the project and task status using a system dashboard, rather than having to chase down employees for reports and updates.

Leverage These Tips to Improve Your Personal and Professional Productivity

If you struggle with time management, you are not alone. Implementing these suggestions should help reduce your stress and give you more control over your schedule over time. Of course, none of these tips will actually give you more time than anyone else has, but they can help you make the most out of every day.

How to Plan Your Day to be More Productive

By Meredith Summers



Improved productivity doesn't just happen overnight. It's a detailed, sometimes painstaking process to lead a better life. However, the more diligently you incorporate these tips, the more likely it is you'll start to see the results you want.

Most people want to figure out ways to get more done in a day, but this type of generic goal will never spur anyone to action. Couple the vagueness with the mixed results everyone gets when they attempt self-improvement, and it makes sense that we all revert to our old habits because at least they're comfortable. Several tips in a blog post, even one as eloquent and masterful as this one, won't fix your productivity problems, but maybe it'll give you a jumping off point.

Don't Wait to Plan

The key to starting your day off right is to begin the night before — and this is especially true on Sundays. Weekends may have been invented to rest, but they're equally likely to leave us feeling more exhausted than before they began. When you go to sleep with the next day hanging over your head like a black cloud, it can make your whole work week that much harder. Get into the habit of taking at least 15 minutes to prepare for the next day. Lay out your clothes, ready the coffee maker, clean and pack your bag, make breakfast, tidy up: do whatever you need to do so you don't wake up in pure panic mode.

Start Your Day with Gratitude

It may sound like new-age hippie mumbo-jumbo, but starting your day off with gratefulness can improve your mental fortitude and [increase your productivity](#) in noticeable ways. There are a number of ways to keep a gratitude journal, but it doesn't have to be complicated. It can be as simple writing down one thing you're grateful a day. The more you focus on the positive in your life, the more likely you are to feel as though you have some control over what happens to you. The more confidence you have, the more likely you are to up your productivity. Nothing kills faith in yourself like stress does.

Exercise Early

Exercising releases a neurotransmitter called GABA, which stands for **Get A Better Attitude** (actually, it may stand for something more science-y than that.) GABA not only makes you feel happier, it can soothe you enough so you feel more in control. Most people don't exercise in the morning because it feels like a tremendous chore — especially when you consider just how uncoordinated non-morning people can be. But exercising doesn't have to be taxing. It could be as simple as just a few minutes of jumping jacks in the morning to get your heart racing before you jump in the shower. Setting small goals and reaching them doesn't just lead you to better productivity, it can actually lead you to happiness. If you reminded yourself of this fact 100 times a day, it still wouldn't be overkill.

Fight Off Indecision Fatigue

All of us have different work styles, and it doesn't help to take to work against your natural body clock. Night owls can learn to be morning people, but there's no point in doing so unless

a nighttime schedule is making the owl unhappy or unproductive. As a general rule though, most of us are freshest in the morning. All the decisions we make throughout the day wear us down — even when they seem trivial. Your brain is taxed with each and every new problem it has to solve. From what tie to wear to how much sugar to put in a coffee cup, it all adds up. It's why we all rely on our routines, and why you shouldn't overload your to-do list. The more you add to your day, the more likely it is you'll either make mistakes or shut down completely.

Tackling It All

Unluckily for us, routines only go so far. It's why it's important to do the toughest things in the morning, and then to take breaks throughout the rest of the day. Sometimes the consequences are rather severe when we push ourselves to keep going. Studies have shown that judges have a tendency to put a lot of effort into deciding their morning cases and practically none at the end. Their productivity at the beginning of the day is focused on justice for those before them, but their productivity at the end is focused on when they'll get to take a nap. Taking a break, eating a snack, or mixing things up is one way to keep yourself on task, but it doesn't necessarily reset our brains 100%. Knowing this can help you restructure your day so you're taking advantage of your brain when it's at its most capable.

Work Smarter

When you're at work, ensure you have all the right tools to facilitate your workflow. If you notice you spend ten minutes searching for files or you have to run through 20 different steps to contact the right person, then it may be time to tighten up your technology. For example, Trello is a company that makes project management software. It ensures everyone is on the same page when it comes to what needs to be done and when. Integrify gives you a way to track your numbers, verify your ROI, and speed up your operations through the power of automation. When you start clearing off full chunks of time you used to devote to busy work, you'll be able to give your time to more important matters.

Start with one of these tips, and then go from there. Also, don't expect instant results. This is the most important thing to remember when you're trying to improve your productivity: it

takes time. It's not necessarily going to happen after a month, six months, or even six years. This is a lifetime commitment that involves being flexible (oh and forgiving yourself.)

Why You Need a Morning Workflow

By Mike Raia



A few months ago after reading a blog post about "[establishing a morning ritual](#)," I decided that it was time to try improving my mornings. Typically I was waking up anywhere between 7 am and 8 am and then scrambling to get ready for the day and make my train into the city. I started to realize that I was causing myself a number of issues by starting the day in such an inconsistent, disorganized way. Basically, I needed a Morning Workflow.

Here's What Led Me Here

Morning stress

Starting mornings off by having to make several decisions in a short amount of time is stressful. Small, seemingly insignificant decisions add up quickly for your waking brain. This invariably leads to anxiety and pressure, starting your brain on the wrong note which can last well into the day.

Add to that the normal anxiety many feel about starting the work day: What do I need to tackle first, second, third? What meetings do I have? What's the status of my project? Who do I

need to call first thing? I wasn't enjoying the whirlwind of unresolved activity and questions each morning and kept feeling like there was a better system.

Bad sleep

The amount of sleep we need is a moving target and, I think, very much specific to the individual. Some people need more; some people need less. All I know for sure is that I wasn't getting what I needed. I also knew that I was engaging in bad sleep habits like staying up too late, browsing news on my phone, checking emails, leaving the TV on, etc.

Also, I was spending the early part of the day in a bit of a haze and downing 3-4 cups of coffee by lunchtime to compensate. Some coffee is good. [Too much coffee is bad](#), leading to everything from twitchiness, nervousness, stomach problems, and insomnia. I wanted to break out of that cycle.

Bad eating habits

If I woke up late (which was happening too often) the odds of me having a good, nutritious breakfast dropped precipitously. Even if I managed to get up on time without the snooze bar, my mornings were so disorganized that I'd end up skipping breakfast anyway, simply because it wasn't a priority. This meant coffee on an empty stomach (bad) or a dubiously-nutritious nutrition bar as I ran to the train.

Plus I was going out to eat almost every day for lunch because I never packed one. Chicago is an amazing place for food and I was taking advantage of it way too often. Bad for my health and bad for my bank account.

Environmental stress

I realized, somewhat after the fact, that one of the things that had been preying on my mind every morning was the fact that there were often dishes left in the kitchen sink from the night before. Raised in a family of excellent cooks, where the kitchen was often the center of our world, keeping the kitchen clean and organized has always been important to me. However, there was that sink full of dishes staring accusingly at me most mornings, [creeping into my subconscious](#). The kitchen is usually the place I start my morning workflow, so I decided it was important to keep it as stress-free as possible.

Workday disorganization

By the time I was getting to work, at a job I happen to enjoy greatly, I was needlessly stressed or feeling burnt for no good reason. That made getting into the swing of the day painful and inefficient. I've always used [task lists](#) and [project planning tools](#), but I wasn't using them as consistently as I should. Part of that was coming from "planning on the fly" instead of thoughtfully and consistently in advance with a clear head and the proper perspective.

Getting Started with a Morning Workflow

Once I realized I needed to change my morning workflow, I started jotting down things I needed to do in the morning as well as things I thought would be helpful.

Doing Now	Need to Do	Even Better
Sleeping poorly and not enough	Get better sleep	Get up earlier and consistently
Showering in a hurry	Shower/Prep without stress	Shower/Prep better and faster
Scrambling for something to wear	Choose clothes/get dressed	Have clothes ready in advance
Running for the last train out	Make the train comfortably	Make an even earlier train
Skipping breakfast most days	Have breakfast	Have a nutritious, energizing breakfast
Doing the bare minimum every morning	Have extra time	Have quality, helpful extra time
Commuting like a zombie	Enjoying my commute	Enjoying my commute productively

One thing you realize quickly when planning a morning workflow is that it's not just about the morning. It's as much, if not more, about the night before. You can't really improve your mornings if you're not shifting much of the responsibility to the evening.

So here's how I sketched out my evening and morning workflows:

Evening

- Clean up the kitchen.
- Make tomorrow's lunches.
- Lay out work and gym clothes for tomorrow.
- Hydrate.
- Stretch.
- Plan tomorrow [using the 1-3-5 Rule](#).
- Power off all electronics 1 hour before bed.
- Go to bed by 10 pm.

Morning

- Rise at 6 am. No snooze.
- Hydrate.
- Stretch.
- Make one cup of coffee.
- Make a nutritious, energizing breakfast.
- Read news (non-digital) for 30 minutes.
- Shower with a cold finish.

A couple things to note:

- This is the latest version of the workflow. It has undergone some tweaks over the first few weeks of using it and probably will undergo more over time.
- I started use a combination of a gentle alarm (my phone) and triggered lighting ([Hue Smart bulbs](#)) to wake up but at this point I just wake up on my own.
- I decided to start drinking green tea in the afternoon to provide a small caffeine boost this made it easier to stick to one cup of coffee per day.
- I use a [Samsung Gear Fit watch](#), which tracks both sleep and activity which has been invaluable for keeping me on track.

- I use [Aqua Notes](#) notepads to capture any stray tasks or ideas that occur to me in the shower.

The Results

I've been doing a version of this morning workflow for about a month and a half and I have to say it's made a big difference in my days. I've had more energy and have been more productive at home and at work. Based on my tracking, I've slept longer and better. By controlling my diet better at breakfast and lunch, along with having the energy to be more active, I've lost about 10lbs.

I'd strongly recommend developing your own Morning/Evening Workflow. Steal some of my ideas, add your own, research more. There are a lot of things I don't do that others have recommended. I'll likely work some of them into what I'm doing to see if they help.

How to Delegate Authority

By Chris Campbell



With the proper plan in place, it's possible to reap the more strategic benefits of delegation without sacrificing day-to-day operational performance.

Many managers have mixed feelings about delegating authority. They know it's vitally important in a broader, abstract sense, yet the practical demands of the workplace often make delegation seem like a more onerous choice. After all, can a manager really ensure stellar results by detaching from the process? At first glance, it might seem like a circle that can't be squared.

Fortunately—with the proper plan in place—it's possible to reap the more strategic benefits of delegation without sacrificing day-to-day operational performance.

To help you accomplish this, let's take a closer look at the primary benefits of delegation, some common barriers to the practice and a few actionable tips for delegating authority effectively.

The Benefits of Delegation

Knowing where, when and how to delegate authority is a critical skill for managers, as it creates more [fluid and efficient workflows](#) and helps employees grow their skills. Yet the benefits of delegation don't stop there.

Other key advantages of learning to delegate effectively include:

- *Creation of a self-renewing talent pipeline.* Delegating authority helps workers cultivate new skills, enhance their capacity for leadership and boost their self-confidence. By granting authority and allowing employees to exercise it, managers ensure that internal replacements will be available when managers move up or move on.
- *Greater trust.* Trust is a two-way street—extend someone your trust in their ability to do the job, and it will likely be reciprocated. Once tasks, projects or decision-making responsibilities have been successfully delegated, the foundation will be set for future collaborations.
- *Deeper insight into employee capabilities.* Delegating authority provides a fantastic window for the evaluation of employee skills and key attributes (creativity, leadership qualities, dependability etc.).
- *Promotion of a culture of innovation.* Fresh ideas and approaches are the lifeblood of business, and delegating authority plays an essential role in granting workers the latitude to develop their own innovative leadership ideas or problem-solving strategies.
- *More motivation.* Personal development and the opportunity to assume greater responsibility are two keys to employee retention. By delegating authority, managers make their co-workers feel respected and trusted, sparking loyalty and motivation.

- *Creation of a healthy organizational culture.* Many businesses can benefit from avoiding over-reliance on a top-down approach to management. Delegating authority is a smart way to make everyone feel invested in the company's progress.

By delegating authority in a smart and strategic fashion, organizations can reap these rewards while cultivating an environment where employees feel trusted and respected.

Given the importance of hiring and retaining talented people, fostering such an atmosphere can deliver a significant competitive edge for organizations prioritizing delegation.

Common Barriers to Delegation

As mentioned above, it's not always a trivial task to delegate authority, even if you're convinced of the overall benefits of the practice. Managers resist delegation for a variety of reasons, but there tend to be a few that crop up consistently.

These common barriers to effective delegation include:

- *Perfectionism.* Some leaders who are afraid to delegate may harbor a fear that the work will suffer without their direct involvement, and that this will reflect poorly upon their own record or reputation.
- *Lower expectations.* Managers who fail to delegate may do so because they believe the work will be slower or less effective when in the hands of employees.
- *Lack of trust.* When you're in a position of accountability, it's sometimes difficult to trust others to get the job done. This is especially true when delegating authority to new people.
- *Concern over losing control.* It's not always easy to share the spotlight, nor is it easy to cede control of an important project or task to another person. Learning to cede control without micromanagement or subsequent interference is a core challenge for delegating managers.
- *Time management issues.* There's no denying that delegating often takes more time, as you need to choose and prepare the right person.
- *The misapprehension about the nature of delegation.* When done properly, delegation doesn't simply "dump extra work" in the laps of employees; it plays a critical role in

their professional development. Workers crave this responsibility in most cases, rather than wishing to avoid it.

By recognizing these barriers or internal impediments to effective delegation, it becomes easier to overcome them. Developing delegation strategies can also play a key role in helping managers transcend these barriers.

Actionable Advice for Delegating More Effectively

You need to get over the idea of losing control. Challenge your own thinking:

- Is every task a high-risk task that only you can solve? If not, start slow and delegate smaller tasks to get comfortable with the idea.
- Are there capable, proven people on my staff who can competently perform tasks? If there are, give them a chance. If not, you either need to re-evaluate your expectations or your hiring process.
- Is this about my own resistance to or fear of mistakes? If this is about you, [you have work to do on yourself](#).
- Do I have trust issues that are preventing me from working with a team? If so, [you have work to do on yourself](#).

You need to recognize that work is a team sport and your teammates, while not perfect, are smart and responsible.

Additional tips you can follow to make the process as seamless as possible.

- It's important to maintain a delegation mindset. Stay vigilant for new opportunities to delegate and match those opportunities with people who have the right mix of skill, leadership, and problem-solving capabilities.
- After finding the right opportunity and the right candidate, ensure that any necessary training or advisory activity is undertaken.
- It's also imperative to maintain open lines of communication. Always be rigorously clear as to what's expected when authority is delegated. Provide clarity as to how

performance will be measured or evaluated. Any deadlines or responsibilities should be clearly articulated and understood.

- Stay in contact but don't be overbearing; the idea is to put people in a position to succeed—to lead and guide rather than do. If you must intervene, use a light touch. Give the person to which you've delegated authority the opportunity to think creatively and independently. Be open to ideas or solutions that run contrary to your normal practice.
- After delegating, make sure you monitor progress. While delegation helps workers develop new skills and leadership qualities, the buck ultimately still stops with the person delegating, so oversight is often necessary for tasks of greater significance.
- Once everything is wrapped up, review the process and get feedback from those involved. Find out what worked and what didn't, and identify potential improvements to be implemented the next time authority is delegated.

The Takeaway

While delegating authority isn't always easy, the process ultimately serves the best interests of managers, employees, and organizations.

By following the steps outlined above, you can begin delegating authority more effectively, improving as a leader while creating professional development opportunities for your co-workers.

Sleep (and Dream) Your Way to Productivity

By Cindy Cook DeRuyter



Getting enough quality sleep every night can be a challenge for busy people but doing so can have a marked increase on productivity at work.

Many working Americans aren't getting enough sleep on a regular basis. When trying to balance work and personal/family commitments, it can seem like there simply are not enough hours in the day to get everything done. If sacrificing sleep is something you do regularly in order to meet daily obligations, you're not alone. Experts recommend getting at least eight hours of sleep. However, according to a [Gallup poll](#), 40 percent of Americans get less than seven hours of sleep each night. When you have a sleep deficit, you may inadvertently be adding to your stress, and hindering your own productivity.

Although it sounds counterintuitive, when you make an effort to get more, and better, sleep on a regular basis, you will not only be taking an important step to improve your health – you can improve your productivity in your day-to-day life.

What Research Tells Us about the Importance of Proper Sleep for Health and Productivity

Study after study has shown that not getting enough sleep can lead to a decrease in overall health, and a corresponding decrease in productivity.

Work absences

According to the [American Academy of Sleep Medicine](#), working adults who get between 7 and 8 hours of sleep each night have the lowest instance of having an extended absence from work because of an illness. Put another way, not getting enough sleep is associated with more work absences – 11.3 days on average – which means decreased productivity. On a national scale, Harvard researchers estimated insomnia costs the U.S. workforce \$63.2 billion, every year.

Performance and productivity

Even if they don't take a sick day from work, sleep-deprived workers are slower at completing their regular tasks. Not surprisingly, accuracy is also negatively impacted when tasks are completed by someone who didn't get enough quality shut-eye the night before. In fact, research has likened being sleep deprived to being under the influence of alcohol.

When we don't get enough sleep, our working memory, attention span, cognitive performance, and the ability to make decisions are all [impacted](#).

Health

Staying up later than normal or getting up early every once in a while shouldn't have much of an impact on your productivity or your health. However, those who don't get enough sleep or who sleep poorly are [at risk for health issues](#) including obesity, cardiovascular disease, diabetes, hypertension, mood disorders, and impaired immune system function. Those who sleep less than five hours a night also face a decreased life expectancy.

How to Get Better Sleep

Don't reach for medication to help you get more sleep; doing so has been linked to an increase in calling in sick for work. Instead, try these tips from the [National Sleep Foundation](#):

- **Aim for consistency.** Try to stick to the same schedule on both weekdays and weekends.
- **Create, and follow, a ritual.** Having a nightly routine before bed can help you transition from a busy day to a relaxing night of sleep. Just try to stay away from bright lights and stressful activities.
- **Exercise.** Getting regular exercise can help you sleep longer, and more soundly.
- **Control your environment.** Make sure you have a comfortable mattress and pillow, and that the temperature in your bedroom is cool. Your room should also be dark and quiet. If a spouse or partner snores, consider using ear plugs, a fan, or white noise machine to help you block out the disruption.
- **Be smart about napping.** Sometimes, a short nap during the day can help you be [more productive](#) without impacting your nighttime sleep. However, naps can also interfere with your sleep schedule. If you are having trouble sleeping at night, try eliminating daytime naps.

Lucid Dreaming and Productivity

As researchers learn more about sleep and its restorative powers, more and more people from all walks of life are trying to harness the power of lucid dreaming to increase productivity. In a lucid dream, you are asleep and dreaming, are fully aware that you're dreaming, and you are exerting a measure of control over your dream.

The idea of controlling dreams isn't anything new, but it's [gaining traction](#). Canadian researchers are using lucid dreaming as part of PTSD treatment, German sleep scientists use it for improving focus and performance in athletes, and dozens of books, videos and even mobile apps about lucid dreaming have sprung up in recent years.

Proponents of lucid dreaming claim it can be used to help solve problems your brain wasn't able to work out during its waking hours, prepare for presentations, and even improve motor skills.

The science of exactly what's going on in your brain during a [lucid dream](#) isn't settled, but the state seems to be somewhere between wakefulness and REM sleep. When you're experiencing a lucid dream, researchers believe you're changing your brain's neuroplasticity, which is the ability of your brain to rewire itself. This can lead to increases in your ability to handle everyday tasks, and can lead to greater productivity at work.

Improving Productivity with Technology

Getting enough, quality sleep every night can have a marked positive impact on both health and on productivity.

To drive even greater productivity, consider your company's technology platform. Is it designed to automate processes, route requests and manage tasks for users? If not, [contact Integrify](#) today to learn about software solutions and services designed to make everyday tasks faster, more accurate, and user-friendly.

Getting enough quality sleep every night can be a challenge for busy people, but doing so can have a marked increase on productivity at work.

How to Be (More) Productive During Unexpected Free Time

By Mike Raia



For many of us, our work days are jam-packed, from the moment we arrive until we finally drag ourselves away from our desks for the day, lamenting “I wish things would slow down, so I could work on [insert a multitude of projects or tasks here.]”

However, when unexpected downtime actually arrives (long afternoon meeting canceled!), the irony is that many people aren’t sure what to do with themselves. There wasn’t time to plan and that list of possible projects or tasks can, itself, seem overwhelming.

If you wind up in the enviable position of having unexpected free time at work, you’ll want to have a strategy for how to make the most of that newly-found time. Here are six ways to be more productive with downtime at work:

Organize

Remember your New Year's resolution to be more organized? When you find extra time in your workday, use it to further that goal.

If your email inbox is overflowing, taking the time to clean and organize it can do more than give you a mental boost – it can help make searching for and finding messages faster, and it can speed up the time needed to backup your email file. Save what you need to save, in a place you'll be able to retrieve them again when needed; delete what you don't need. Not sure where to start? Fast Company offers 7 tips on how to get to the bottom of your inbox [in this article](#).

Downtime is also perfect for helping you sort through the small mountain of paper that's accumulated on your desk including stickies, business cards and meeting notes. Sort, file or distribute what needs to be retained, and dispose of the rest. For instance, you'll likely find that 85%-90% of your meeting notes aren't worth keeping because they aren't actionable anymore or have become irrelevant. Turn the rest into action plans and then prioritize them.

Also, don't underestimate the power of organizing and cleaning your physical space. Look around your desk/cube/office and determine if there are potential stresses you've just consciously blocked out but still affect your mood. That tangle of cords, those unsightly coffee stains, the gathering dust. Many people find that sitting back down to a clean and neat work area has a noticeable impact on their mood.

Plan

It's hard to get where you're going without a road map; the same is true for your professional life. Sometimes though, we get so caught up in the day-to-day tasks that it's hard to find the time to plan for the coming week or month, for upcoming projects or long-term department or organizational initiatives. Generate a list of projects or initiatives that you believe will make a difference in next few months and then use a prioritization framework or [decision matrix](#) to decide what should be done first.

If you only have a short time and want to both plan and get things done during your free time, keep the matrix simple:



You can also consider using an "[Eisenhower Box](#)" which is similar to the box above but where importance and urgency are considered over impact and effort. The point is, choose a system to help you process your list.

Another important planning area to consider is succession planning. In other words, planning for what would happen to your responsibilities if you weren't there to handle them for a day, a week, a month, or longer. It isn't necessarily a fun topic, but it can be critical to your department's or your organization's success – particularly if you are in a management or other leadership role. See [this Business.com article](#) for tips on getting started.

Read

Unexpected downtime offers a great time to get caught up on those industry publications that have been circulating through your department or division (or sitting in a "to-be-read" folder in your email inbox.) Or you might have grabbed a Fast Company issue with an intriguing cover article or an interesting vendor brochure from a recent tradeshow. Now is a good time to dig in and see if there's anything to learn. That also goes for articles and blog posts you've saved to [Pocket](#) or a similar service.

Getting caught up on your work-related reading can help give you some needed perspective and can help you re-focus efforts to make the most of your time and department resources. You might also discover some projects to consider (see the previous tip).

Develop Your Skills

Whether or not you are in an industry that requires ongoing continuing education, everyone can benefit from personal and professional development.

Maybe your company recently implemented a new software tool, but you aren't sure how to use more than just the basic features of it. Downtime is a great time to take the initiative to learn how various bells and whistles work.

If your industry offers specialized certifications or advanced designations, maybe it's time to think about pursuing a new credential. And, if you do have a continuing education mandate, being proactive about completing your requirements ahead of time during slow periods at work can help ease the stress and strain of being under the proverbial gun with a deadline looming.

Being deliberate about using your downtime to develop your skill sets can not only make you more productive at work; it can also make you more valuable to your employer.

Network

Networking with colleagues in your office or in your industry is about more than just making connections and increasing your visibility; it can be a valuable way to learn about best practices that you can use in your own job.

Attending industry conferences or meetings is a great way to meet new connections, but you can also engage in some networking right from your office chair thanks to professional networking tools like LinkedIn.

If you aren't sure where to start, [this Forbes article](#) offers eight tips on how to make the most of professional networking.

Breathe

Last, but certainly not least, give yourself permission to relax every once in a while. Keeping up a blistering pace for too long can actually hamper your productivity, and lead to burnout.

When you allow yourself to have some quiet time to reflect and refresh your mind, you'll be ready to attack your to-do list with renewed vigor.

Remember that you have a life outside the office too. Don't feel guilty for taking some time to schedule or attend personal appointments, or to be there for an important event for a child or another family member. The most important thing about work-life balance is the balance part.

How to Stay Productive When Dealing with Negative Co-Workers

By Meredith Summers



Dealing with negative coworkers on a regular basis can sap your strength, darken your mood and prevent you from having a productive day. We share some tips for making sure that you can remain positive and productive despite a negative environment.

You likely don't need a cited study to prove negative co-workers can have a major effect on how much you get done in a day, but we'll let you in on a small statistic anyway. An Associate Professor at Georgetown University and her colleagues found that a constantly pessimistic and negative coworker affects you [up to seven times](#) more than a co-worker who spreads nothing but good cheer. That rough reality translates into hours worth of loss in productivity and potentially worse. See just how important attitudes are in a workplace, and what can be done to avoid falling into a trap — whether you're a CEO, a manager, or a frustrated colleague.

Recognize the Signs

Employees affected by the negativity of their coworkers may start to feel as though they're on an island. They'll share less, work less, and may even complain more. They may start going through extreme measures to avoid coming into contact with the negative coworkers in their circle. Staff will worry (or even obsess) about why they're so affected by someone else's mood, and why they can't tolerate their behavior. There may be many separate dynamics going on in any one office, making it harder for leadership to dissect these types of signs, but failing to recognize them will make for lower morale.

Planning Ahead

A good leader can do wonders when it comes to dealing with negative employees, and it all comes down to finding the right balance of interaction. It's generally recommended that there should be [some level of isolation](#) for the negative employee, at least for the time being. A negative attitude is a core trait, and it's not going to be changed by a few positive phrases or even several lectures. This doesn't mean that the co-worker has to be set off adrift on the company's version of an ice floe forever though. There are things that can be done to encourage trust within the workplace, but it will take time and careful thought. Changing an employee's attitude from negative to positive is not impossible, but it doesn't happen overnight.

A negative attitude is a core trait, and it's not going to be changed by a few positive phrases or even several lectures.

Divide and Conquer

Workplaces have seen success when negativity is removed almost entirely from the office. This might involve redistributing talent, limiting the number of meetings, and even letting people work from home. (As a side note, some studies show people who work from home can actually be [13% more productive](#) than those in the office.) It's not unusual for major companies to build separate areas for the most valued members of their team who also happen to be extremely negative. For consistently pessimistic employees who still care about their productivity levels, isolation can actually be as much of a boon for them as for the rest of their team. They may want to be left alone so they can get more done.

The Spider Effect

When a high performer is surrounded by negative attitudes, [they're 13 times more likely](#) to leave their position than they are to be dragged down with the people around them. In a sense, this is good news in that high performers have a strong work ethic that can't be broken, but horrible news for a company that wants to retain its talent. Happiness and negativity can spread not just between close ties in a workplace, but even by the most casual of encounters. So if a sales coworker's hot dog was delivered without relish (when they specifically asked for relish!), you may find yourself responding to their anger all the way over in IT. When this negativity is constant and recurring, it needs to be addressed.

Be Assertive

If there's currently no way around dealing with a negative coworker, nothing stops the spread of their attitude as much as assertion does. Negative people are generally looking for people to feed off their anger and disappointment, but they'll stop once they know they won't get anywhere. While politeness often calls us to participate in conversations that aren't productive, there are ways to exit them without coming across as rude. Simply telling the negative person that you prefer to think positively about your position at the company can go a long way to affirming your own feelings about your job. Regardless of how the negative employee takes the departure, others will certainly notice it as a clear attempt at setting boundaries.

The key is to develop a real sense of trust in the negative employee, which can allow them to start seeing the value of collaboration and cooperation.

Don't Argue

Arguing with a negative employee will not get you anywhere, and unfortunately, they're more likely to hold onto their attitudes than you are. In one study done at a large manufacturing firm that spanned across more than 30 countries, those who reported the most negativity were found to be 30% less happy than colleagues who felt the organization was doing just fine. This gap makes it much more likely you won't win an argument, either literally or figuratively. Those who are negative are not likely to respond to statistics and facts. The odds are the emotional side will negate the logical side, firmly digging in its proverbial heels

regardless of sound reasoning. While it's not healthy for anyone, the negative employee is comfortable to a certain extent feeling the way they feel. Their pessimistic view may have been around long before they stepped foot in the company, and will be difficult to change.

Turn the Beat Around

If you want to do more than just isolate an employee, then there are steps you can take to turn things around, but again, it will take time. Negative employees can have their emotions redirected by consistent reinforcement that they are indeed a valuable and contributing member of the organization. These efforts don't have to be done in stealth either, they can be done right out in the open. Despite transparency, employees are likely to respond to this. In fact, they may be even more willing to absorb the message if there is no subterfuge. The key is to develop a real sense of trust in the negative employee, which can allow them to start seeing the value of collaboration and cooperation.

Think of the Rewards

The concept of rewarding negativity (with extra attention) or catering to the needs of a negative employee may seem counter-intuitive. However, if the employee is valuable to the company and you feel their attitude can be rescued, it's worth the effort. Fellow employees will hopefully see it as a clear sign that the company cares about the people they hire. The key is to practice these habits of respect on a larger scale for the good of everyone. These steps can go a long way to increase collaboration *as long as they're done with the right intentions*. It would be better to fully isolate yourself from the employee entirely than to try to act as though you feel a relationship that just isn't there. While 'fake it until you make it' may work in some situations, this is not likely to be one of them.

Integrify [streamlines workflow processes](#) to increase everyone's productivity. By eliminating redundant tasks, our products can boost employee confidence to create a better environment. The right software won't solve every problem, but it can certainly help when it comes to encouraging employees to get more done.

Real World Productivity Tips for Telecommuters

By Meredith Summers



If you're one of the [23% of workers](#) who does some type of remote work, you probably already have opinions about what it means to have a home office. While there's little doubt the flexibility of the role will inspire jealousy in others, it's not necessarily a dream come true. Telecommuting has a lot of perks, but it can also feel incredibly isolating. Without the external pressure to finish tasks and maintain a schedule, things can fall apart pretty quickly. Follow these tips as a way to tighten up your day and get more done.

Real-World Statistics

Before you learn about how to get better at working from home, you should have some context about its role in business as a whole. Around 80% of remote workers report they're

more productive when they're not in the office, and on average, do about 13% more work every day than employees in the office. Rather than feeling less invested in the company, 87% feel more connected to their work. This is all great news, but that doesn't mean it's a perfect system. Only 67% of managers say their employees are as productive when working from home. So still pretty good, but there's a bit of a disconnect there (whether perceived or not.)

Getting everything done (correctly and on time) is your first priority — not ensuring you take a short break every day at 10 a.m.

Stop Focusing on the Schedule

Having a schedule is important, there's no doubt about that. Some creative types thrive on erratic hours, but you're likely not one of those people. The real trick though is to ensure you can work within your limits. Getting everything done (correctly and on time) is your first priority — not ensuring you take a short break every day at 10 a.m. Eventually, your body will let you know how and when it wants to operate.

The Power of Habit

Charles Duhigg, the author of *The Power of Habit*, did an analysis about high- and low-performers in a particular sales office. He found the top performer was absolutely meticulous about his routine. Not only would he get everything he needed ready at night, but he did things like programming his coffee maker to have a steaming cup ready as soon as he awoke. These types of positive actions program your brain to be more productive, particularly when you work from home. The most amazing takeaway from this tip is that you don't have to transform your whole routine (and you shouldn't even try.) Focus on one pattern of behavior you want to change, like hitting the snooze button, and target it until you've effectively corrected the behavior. Also, throw out the whole 30-day rule to enforce a habit, you change at your own pace.

Experiment and Forgive

If you find yourself idly wandering around the house or clicking around online when you hit a difficult problem, you may want to consider trying something new. Happiness is typically measured by small, reachable goals, and too many failures can take your productivity from bad to worse. Focus on something you find fulfilling to clear out the cobwebs, and then get

back to work. Also, you'll need to learn to forgive yourself when you make mistakes during this process. There is often no one to give you feedback when you work at home, and you're likely your own worst critic. If you've just spent an hour looking at vacation rentals when you should have been processing reports, you can't let that downward spiral of shame stand in the way of getting back on track.

If you find yourself idly wandering around the house or clicking around online when you hit a difficult problem, you may want to consider trying something new.

Get Some Social Interaction

Too much alone time is horrible for people, regardless of how frustrating it can be to deal with people sometimes. Remote workers benefit from getting out whenever and however they can. Most coffee shops will have some combination of electric outlets and Wi-Fi, so make use of the portability to get more done. If you need to stay in your home office, at least try to get out for lunch. No matter how trivial it may seem, even brief encounters with restaurant employees can provide some relief to being alone all day.

Don't Live and Die with Your Deadlines

It's so tempting to wait until the last minute when you work from home — after all, you can work all night if you really wanted and co-workers won't be around to judge (we can't speak for your family.) Unless you have specific deliverables to hit throughout the day, you may find yourself putting certain things off. But acting on the same instincts as a college kid won't make you a better professional. This may be a good time to rely on another co-worker to check in with throughout the day or to impose strict rules on yourself about milestones and rewards. For example, you'll only let yourself have a treat when you've hit the halfway point for a project.

Do More with Less

Working more hours doesn't necessarily [translate to better work](#). While work ethic is extremely important when it comes to being productive from home, that doesn't mean pushing through those last few hours is actually doing you any good. Your brain isn't equipped to be pushed past a certain brink, and it's not worth forcing it. Instead of concentrating on how many hours you've worked, concentrate on the quality of work

you've done. If you get inspired at 8 p.m., then jump back online and start cranking things out. A schedule with zero flexibility is only likely to imprison your productivity.

Use the Right Tools

If software is slow or inefficient, you'll find yourself dreading certain tasks when you're working from home. You may even try to find solutions that allow you to avoid using the proper protocol (e.g., sending an email when you should be sending a task.) The right combination of communication and automation can not only free up more time to do more, it can help you hit a groove you might not have even realized was possible. Even the most productive employees out there are always looking for that next subtle edge, and part of that edge is having the right tools. Check out tools like [Trello](#), [Slack](#), [Google Keep](#) and [articles like these](#) to get ideas for productivity tools.

Eat Better

Your eating habits will have a lot to do with how you function throughout the day, so don't neglect them. Unfortunately, cooking for one isn't necessarily easy (no matter how many people tell you it is.) Salads, pasta, and sandwiches are all good options, but it will be a struggle not to head to the kitchen every time you get frustrated. While it can be expensive, going out for something healthy can really improve your outlook and nutrient level — especially if you're one of the many snackers that walk amongst us.

Pick Up the Phone

It's easy to assume other people either already know what you're up to or don't need to know. But the confusion that arises from a lack of communication is often what causes managers and owners to completely outlaw the practice of working from home. Untangling communication mishaps will cut into your overall productivity, so start working on the art of the update. When anything significant happens, send an email or pick up the phone. Excessive phone calls aren't recommended of course, but a few throughout the week encourage relationships while providing the means to explain some of the more complicated aspects of your work.

Does This Really Have to Be a Meeting?

By Meredith Summers



There's little doubt meetings are a double-edged sword for most people in business. Sometimes they smooth out communication gaps, but other times they seem to drain people's will to live. In fact, excessive meetings are usually the culprit behind those 70-hour work weeks. A full [70% of employees](#) state they don't even think meetings help them get work done. So before you block off the time for that conference room, consider the following.

From the Mouths of Executives

It's often the executives of major companies who come down hardest on meetings. [Al Pittampalli](#) from Ernst & Young wrote a whole book about how meetings create a hive mind that practically guarantees nothing gets done, and how they often skew the importance of actual productivity. Since business isn't an exact science, companies can get trapped in bad patterns quickly when it comes to meetings. Pittampalli stresses the importance of using meetings as an opportunity to connect with people to get one particular task done — and that

task should not be making major decisions. Before you schedule or attend a meeting, ask yourself the following questions.

Calling Meetings

Have You Considered Every Angle?

Before calling everyone together, you should have thought through the scope, milestones, and workflow of the problem in front of you. Much of the time, meetings are scheduled to move a project forward, but they can limit progress by complicating the matter. Taking an extra hour or two to consider the moving parts helps you boil down the problem, so you can present it in such a way that saves everyone's time (and brain power.) The last thing you want to do is stunt creativity or interrupt people's thoughts with mind-numbing information. In doing so, you may even decide that you don't need anyone else's input to make a final decision.

If you don't actually need to see someone face-to-face, then consider sending an email, making a quick phone call, or sending out a group chat message.

Do You Need to See Someone Face-to-Face?

This question doesn't discount the importance of working relationships. We all know how dangerous it is to rely on technology to communicate rather than taking the time to interact with someone. But if you don't treat people's time with a profound amount of respect, they won't do the same for you. Bottom line: If you don't need to see someone face-to-face, then consider sending an email, making a quick phone call, or sending out a group chat message.

Is the Meeting Likely to Get Off Track?

If you're calling people together for a vague goal, you can't be upset if the conversation starts to get discombobulated. While some people look at these brainstorming sessions as helpful for the company, most of the time they just twist people's brains in circles. For creative types, this can end up sparking a new idea that propels the business forward. However, for those who just want to tackle their to-do list, they're not going to appreciate being called into a meeting that ends up straying into topics far outside the realm of routine business matters. Try to imagine how the meeting will go and how you think all the participants will

react to spending the time to come to your meeting. Will they either find or provide value? If not, pare down the conference list to value adders or receivers.

Is It Easy to Come Up with an Agenda?

Meetings that need to happen should practically write their own agenda. The meeting leader should be there to cover select, straightforward points. Once it's over, employees should understand the updates and their role in the company moving forward. This is why experts caution against bringing in a team to make major decisions for the company. The more you open the floor for opinions (and the more opinions you get), the more likely it is that the agenda will fly out the window.

Attending Meetings

Instead of just blindly hitting accept to every invite you receive for a meeting, you should consider whether or not you should commit your time. There are questions you need to ask yourself before you leave your desk.

What Do I Get Out of This?

Meetings don't have to be inherently interesting or fun to be productive, so that's not how you should evaluate what you're getting out of the meeting. However, if you're always hearing the same information repeated over and over again, it likely means you can skip the meeting without repercussion. Maybe only one small slice of the meeting even involves you, with the rest of it feeling superfluous. And of course, the ultimate sign you're getting nothing out of the meeting: you're doing other work while people are talking. Question why you're working on other business in regular meetings. Is it because you're overwhelmed with work or is this simply not a good use of your time? Discuss it with the meeting organizer afterward.

And of course, the ultimate sign you're getting nothing out of the meeting: you're doing other work while people are talking.

Will People Be Prepared?

Consider whether or not people will be prepared when they step into the meeting. For the most part, this means asking whether or not the person who called the meeting will be prepared. It's the leader's job to keep everyone on track and ensure they're only inviting people who will show up with something to say. If you've noticed the meeting leader relies on

others to dictate where the meeting heads, then you don't need that kind of distraction in your day.

The Other Side

Saying no to a meeting can be difficult in small businesses where there are only a few people, as your refusal is likely to single you out and potentially make you seem difficult. To some degree, time-wasting meetings are a symptom of a poor company culture is, of course, going to be difficult to change. Organizations should consider the opportunity cost of meetings, that is, what more valuable work could be getting done instead of attending meetings? No matter how tricky it is to broach the subject though, your superiors should be open to hearing about how excessive meetings hinder your productivity.

The Bottom Line

Meetings can be a good way to get everyone on the same page, but they often waste the most valuable resource in a company. If too many meetings are what's stopping you from having a better work-life balance, then it's time to come up with a better workflow. To save your productivity (and sanity), stop the madness by refusing to call or attend another pointless get-together.

How to Help Your Team Realize Untapped Potential

By Mike Raia



All managers have employees who can do more for their company and own careers. Realizing this untapped potential requires an understanding of your role as a manager, the personality types and motivations of your employees, and a variety of proven management techniques. This post discusses the strategies that allow managers to help their employees achieve their full potential.

An organization's greatest untapped resource is usually its employees. [Gallup Research](#) reports that organizations typically use less than 20 percent of their employees' potential, which includes their skills, creativity and general resourcefulness. The key to unlocking this potential is more than simply motivating current employees to give 100 percent of their effort. The most successful companies excel at recruiting and retaining the best employees. The specific techniques for helping team members realize their untapped potential include the following:

- Identifying Personality Types
- Understanding Emotional intelligence

- Focusing on Retention
- Improving Communication
- Fostering Empowerment
- Providing Recognition

Identify Personality Types

[Peter Honey, Teams and Leaders, 1984](#) describes four common personality types among employees, including Doers, Carers, Thinkers and Achievers. There have been many other variations on this theme over the years, but they all fall into similar types. A team will typically include a variety of these types, which can complement each other under the right leadership. You can probably recognize these types within your own team:

- **Doers** give the team drive and ensure the job gets done. They're willing to help others by getting involved in their work. Doers also hate wasting time and want to see continual progress on a project.
- **Carers** keep the team together by promoting harmony and easing tensions. They're also sensitive to the relationships between team members and want everyone to fit in.
- **Thinkers** like to find solutions to problems. They're typically good at getting good ideas and rejecting bad ones.
- **Achievers** want their projects to succeed and strive to achieve good results. Like Doers, they become impatient with delays.

Recognizing these types within your team will help you determine the best methods for helping each team member feel comfortable and appreciated enough to spread their wings. It also helps managers understand how to pair up team members for better results. Pairing a Doer with a Thinker, for instance.

Emotional Intelligence

[Emotional intelligence](#) is a set of skills that leaders and team members can use to effectively develop and apply their "people skills." These skills including the following:

- Adaptability

- Communication
- Commitment
- Conflict management
- Conscientiousness
- Innovativeness
- Optimism
- Self-confidence
- Self-control
- Understanding others

These skills provide staff members with invaluable assistance in excelling at their jobs, thus becoming star performers. Team members with the most effective emotional intelligence also understand how to best channel their efforts to achieve more productive results. Identifying gaps in emotional intelligence and then addressing them with team members can improve the professionalism of the team in general and foster better collaboration.

For instance, recognizing team members who lack optimism and finding ways to get them excited about their work (or finding them work they CAN get excited about) will elevate the mood of team meetings and give the team a sense of momentum. It also provides a safer environment for innovative ideas because team members are less afraid of being shot down by pessimistic thinking.

Retention

All organizations need to attract and retain talented workers with exceptional skills. This goal is often challenging for many organizations, largely due to the competition for these workers. In fact, the job market is very much in favor of job seekers currently, an issue we run into when hiring here in our Chicago headquarters. Finding the right people goes beyond simply matching needed skills with past experience. It also includes identifying candidates who you can easily imagine working as part of the team. Once you've had a chance to get to know them through the interview process:

- Can you positively picture their interactions with other team members?

- Do they fill a missing piece of the team, for instance, Doer, Carer, Thinker, Achiever (or whatever "personality type" model you use)?
- Do they understand any differences in this environment compared to their past environments? For instance, in interviews, I always ensure candidates are comfortable with the size and pace of our company, especially if they're coming from a very large, corporate-style organization. Other changes to consider: non-profit vs. profit, B2B vs. B2C, high-growth vs. stable growth, structured vs. unstructured.
- Do they seem coachable, either by you or other team members with more experience?

Having the skills to perform the job is critical, but it should only be part of your requirements for long-term retention.

Another area that often gets missed with hiring is the [employee onboarding process](#). We've written a lot about the topic of [automating employee onboarding](#), and it can [make or break the first few months](#) of an employee's tenure. Getting a new employee ramped up and working confidently should be a significant focus.

Developing the untapped potential of the employees provides a competitive advantage that offers a high return on investment (ROI) for a manager's time. Developing their skills through training and coaching also helps improve their job satisfaction, which is a key factor in retention. Employees with the most potential will typically prefer new challenges rather than continually performing the same tasks over and over. Find ways to [automate rote, manual tasks](#) so they can focus on adding value in new, creative ways.

Communication

Leaders must be able to communicate with their staff effectively about the best way to complete a project. This technique generally involves asking staff members for their suggestions on how to perform required tasks as part of coaching efforts. Some companies rely on six-month or quarterly review cycles to provide employees with feedback. I've found that these meetings can be helpful but nowhere near as helpful as providing continuous feedback and asking for the same.

A mentor of mine had a habit of randomly asking "How would you rate your job satisfaction on a scale of 1-10?" My answer would spur further discussion. If I said "7," he'd say, "Interesting, how can we get that close to 9 or 10?" This forced me to think about what was driving my feelings. Was it a temporary issue or a systemic one? I have always found this to be a valuable way of garnering good feedback from my teams.

The same mentor was a fervent believer in the need to communicate your expectations and give clear direction to team members on what they need to do to meet those expectations. Without expectations, employees can end up going in the wrong direction (or no direction at all) and end up surprised later when you react poorly. There should be no surprises about what you expected. When your team members consistently understand and meet your expectations, they can begin moving on to bigger responsibilities.

Empowerment

Empowerment is the process of allowing employees to make decisions and take responsibility for them. It increases team members' engagement with their work in addition to boosting their self-confidence and providing them with a sense of accomplishment that can propel them forward. Effective empowerment requires managers to recognize the difference between someone who is ready but reluctant and someone who is reluctant because they're not ready. This means reviewing the employees work and understanding what's causing them to miss the mark. Is it a lack of focus, a lack of training, a lack of context, ineffective tools?

If you think someone is ready but reluctant, there are ways to build their confidence and help them envision themselves taking on new responsibilities.

- Set up scenarios related to potential new responsibilities and ask questions about how they'd handle them.
- Ask them to come up with ideas about how to do things differently.
- Give them a new low-impact, less visible project that's out of their comfort zone and discuss the results.

Ultimately empowerment is about trust and every interaction with your team can either increase or diminish their ability to trust you and themselves. You need to push them out

onto the tightrope but you also need to help them stay balanced and be the net when they fall.

Recognition

Leaders should recognize the accomplishments of their staff members by praising them and providing positive feedback regularly. Again, there is certainly a benefit to providing positive feedback on a set, quarterly or 6-month schedule but that's a lot of time between praise. It takes no time for managers to observe when their team members are doing well and let them know. "Nice job on the contract review, you caught some potentially serious mistakes!" or "Great email to Acme Co. Very clear and actionable! That should help things move forward." Genuine appreciation for good performance is one of the most effective techniques for increasing an employee's motivation in the workplace and giving them the confidence to do more.

Why What You Listen to at Work Can Make You More Productive

By Deanna deBara



Music and other audio can boost physical performance, improve efficiency, and make it easier to work through tedious, repetitive tasks—so what should you listen to?

Everyone has days where getting things done feels next to impossible. Maybe you're tired. Maybe you're stressed out. Or maybe you're just feeling overwhelmed by all the tasks on your ever-growing to-do list. You try to motivate yourself to start tackling your to-do's, but for whatever reason, you just can't muster up the energy to actually work—and instead, you find yourself staring blankly at your computer screen.

We've all been there. And in those moments, finding the motivation to get things done can be a real challenge. But on those days where productivity is a struggle, there is a solution—and it may be as simple as slipping on a pair of headphones.

What you listen to at work—and, more specifically, the music you listen to at work—can have a profound effect on your mood, your motivation, and your overall productivity. But how, exactly, does music influence your ability to get things done? And, more importantly, when you're feeling unmotivated at work, what should you add to your playlist to deliver the productivity boost you need to power through?

How what you listen to at work impacts productivity

You might think of your playlist as background noise to keep your office from getting too quiet—but the truth is, the music you play while you work directly impacts your productivity in a variety of ways. And the first? Your mood.

Stress is a productivity killer; when you're feeling stressed out and overwhelmed, it's much harder to focus and get things done. But [music can actually lower your body's stress response](#) and put you in a better (and more productive) mood. In fact, music is such an effective stress-reliever, one study (explored in this [meta-analysis on the neurochemistry of music](#)) found that patients who listened to music before surgery experienced less anxiety and lower levels of cortisol (the stress hormone) than patients who were given anti-anxiety drugs. So, essentially, music can help you feel less stressed and calmer, which can put you in a better frame of mind to work through your to-do list.

Music can also increase the quality of your work. [One study](#) found that listening to music helped workers perform their tasks faster and think more creatively—so if you're struggling through a brainstorming session, the right music can help you power through your meeting and come up with your next big idea.

Music can also [boost physical performance](#), [improve efficiency](#), and make it easier to [work through tedious, repetitive tasks](#). Basically, music can make you more productive at work in virtually every way.

But not all music is created equal—and if you want to enjoy music's productivity-boosting benefits, you need to listen to the right music.

What to listen to at work to boost productivity



So, if you want to get the most productivity bang for your buck, what kind of music should you be listening to at work?

Nature sounds

Spending time in nature has a [plethora of health benefits](#)—many of which can help improve productivity. But if you can't get outside in the middle of the workday, it turns out that listening to nature sounds can be just as effective.

[Recent research](#) has found that listening to nature sounds can reduce stress (including lowering muscle tension, heart rate, and stress response) in as little as five to seven minutes. Nature sounds were also found to improve focus and concentration.

If you want to harness the productivity-boosting power of nature—without leaving your office—try playing nature sounds (like ocean waves or thunderstorms) while you work.

Want to get a nature-inspired productivity boost? Check out [Spotify's Nature Sounds playlist](#), which has nature sounds straight from the ocean, sky, forest, and other landscapes.

Classical music

As mentioned, when it comes to productivity, not all music is created equal—and music with lyrics (especially lyrics you’re tempted to sing along to!) can actually be distracting, making it harder to get work done instead of easier ([one study](#) found that listening to “familiar vocal music” can actually cause performance to decrease, particularly for introverts).

Classical music is a great choice to reap the productivity-boosting benefits of listening to music at work—without the distraction of lyrics. [Research shows that classical music from the Baroque period](#) can improve efficiency and accuracy at work—so next time you’re struggling to get things done, try listening to compositions from Vivaldi, Handel, or Bach.

Want to listen to classical music at work (and get more done in the process)? Tune in to [YourClassical Radio](#) for a variety of classical channels, including Peaceful Piano and SymphonyCast.

Binaural beats

Every sound has its own frequency. And when you listen to sounds with two different frequencies (one in each ear), your brain compensates for the difference and creates a third frequency known as a binaural beat.

Binaural beats change the frequency of your brain waves—which you can use to induce a specific state of mind, including increased productivity. [One study found](#) that listening to binaural beats in the gamma range (40 Hz and above) increased cognitive flexibility—while [another](#) found that theta-frequency binaural beats (four to seven Hz) can help decrease sympathetic nervous system activity (also known as “fight or flight” mode) and help people feel more relaxed.

Are binaural beats music? That might be a stretch. But using binaural beats to improve productivity at work? That’s not a stretch at all.

Want to give binaural beats a try? Check out the [Binaural Beats Library on Spotify](#), pop in your headphones, and get to work!

Functional music

Clearly, music influences productivity. But if you want to take music's productivity-boosting benefits to the next level, why not try music specifically designed to enhance productivity?

[Brain.fm](#) has created what they call "functional music"—music engineered to induce specific mental states and improve focus. While binaural beats change your brain state by influencing your brain waves, Brain.fm's music takes it to the next level, impacting the brain (and productivity) using [a number of science-backed strategies](#), including salience reduction (removing attention-diverting sound effects), neural phase-locking (which "allows populations of neurons to engage in various kinds of coordinated activity"), and 3D effects to induce deep relaxation.

And unlike binaural beats or ambient music, which have a distinctly electronic sound, Brain.fm's functional music is composed by actual musicians—so the music is just as enjoyable as it is productivity-boosting.

Use music to improve productivity

Everyone has days when productivity is a struggle. But with the right playlist, you'll have everything you need to get focused, get creative, and get back to work. Happy listening!